

BIOL 1113 · OKLAHOMA
STATE UNIVERSITY

Introductory Biology

Fall 2026 · Concurrent Enrollment

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FORMAT

Online · Asynchronous

Exams via ProctorU or Testing Center

VIRTUAL OFFICE HOURS

TBD — see Zoom link on Canvas

Or schedule a meeting

CREDIT HOURS

3 Credit Hours

Concurrent Enrollment

What is Introductory Biology?

Biology is the science of life — the study of everything from microscopic molecules to entire ecosystems. This course is designed to give you a strong foundation in the core concepts of biology so that you're ready to dive deeper into more advanced topics later in your college career. Along the way, you'll start to see how these concepts connect, giving you a greater appreciation for the complexity (and beauty!) of living systems.

Course Format

This course is taught online via asynchronous instruction through the course Canvas page, with exams taken via [Measure Learning/ProctorU](#) or scheduled by you at a registered testing center.

What to Call Your Instructor

At the college level, particularly in the biological sciences, your instructors all have terminal degrees (the highest possible degree in our field: Ph.D.). It is appropriate to call us *Dr.* or *Professor*. You may call me Dr. Wiggins or Professor Wiggins. [History of the title “doctor”](#)

Communication

Your success is important.

Please do not hesitate to contact me at any time — I am here to help! The best way to reach me is through email at jodie.wiggins@okstate.edu. I respond to all emails within 24 hours in most cases. I do not respond to messages after 5 PM or on weekends. You can also visit virtual office hours (see Zoom link on Canvas) or schedule a face-to-face meeting.

My Teaching Philosophy

My teaching philosophy for concurrent enrollment courses centers on the idea that carefully designed learning materials can create a rigorous, engaging, and equitable learning environment even when students interact with the content outside of a traditional university classroom.

Instructional videos are typically short — generally under ten minutes — to support attention and reduce unnecessary cognitive load. Each video is accompanied by clear guidance about what students should focus on while watching. By explicitly identifying the key ideas or questions students should be considering, I help direct attention toward the most important conceptual relationships rather than passive viewing.

Assigned readings are organized around specific topics rather than traditional textbook chapters, allowing students to focus on the most relevant concepts. This approach reflects my broader view of learning as an active cognitive process. Students develop durable understanding when they revisit challenging ideas, make connections across topics, and apply biological principles to new situations.

Ultimately, my goal is to create a learning environment that maintains the rigor and expectations of a university biology class while providing students with the structure and clarity needed to engage deeply with the material.

Canvas & Weekly Modules

Log in to Canvas every Monday morning.

Each week a new module will become accessible on Monday morning. It will include all of your assignments for the week: lecture videos, readings, and sometimes additional media such as podcasts. Assignments are open from Monday morning through Sunday at 11:59 PM — six days to complete them. They will not be reopened.

Make sure your preferred email is set up in Canvas so you receive notifications. Resources to help you get started with Canvas include the [Student Canvas Videos](#) and the [Passport to Canvas](#) learning modules.

Required Materials

This course uses Open Educational Resources (OERs) — there is no textbook to purchase. Our primary text is the freely available online **OpenStax Biology 2e**. Reading assignments will be linked either to this book or other freely available resources as appropriate.

Regular Substantive Interaction

To meet federal requirements for online courses and to ensure you have meaningful access to your instructor throughout the semester, I am committed to the following:

- Responding to student communication within 24 hours (excepting weekends)
- Holding regular, consistent virtual office hours
- Providing feedback on student formative assessments

TO ADD:

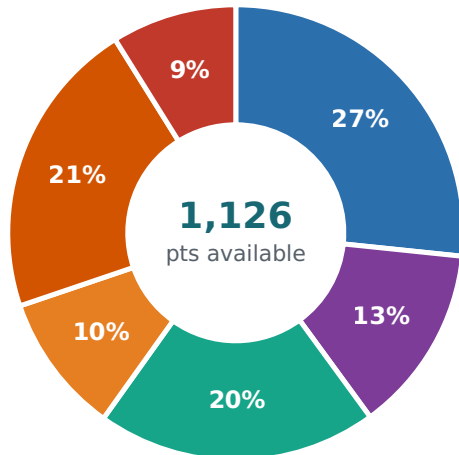
Meet & Greet Virtual Meeting — Students will be required to schedule a brief virtual meeting with Dr. Wiggins during the first two weeks of the semester. Details about scheduling, format, and how this counts toward RSI requirements will be added here. [Add specific instructions, scheduling link, and any grading/participation implications before the course opens.]

After completing this course, students will be able to:

1. **Explain how scientific knowledge is generated and evaluated** so that they can interpret biological claims, distinguish evidence-based conclusions from unsupported assertions, and critically evaluate scientific information in everyday life.
 2. **Design biological investigations and interpret experimental data** so that they can evaluate hypotheses, analyze graphs and datasets, and draw evidence-based conclusions about biological processes.
 3. **Explain how the structure of biological molecules, cells, and systems relates to their function** so that they can predict how changes in structure (such as mutations, environmental changes, or disease) influence biological outcomes.
 4. **Describe how genetic information is stored, transmitted, and expressed in living organisms** so that they can explain how traits arise, how mutations generate variation, and how genetic information influences phenotype.
 5. **Explain how cell division and inheritance mechanisms generate genetic diversity** so that they can predict patterns of inheritance and understand how meiosis, recombination, and fertilization contribute to variation in populations.
 6. **Explain the mechanisms of evolutionary change** so that they can interpret how mutation, natural selection, genetic drift, gene flow, and speciation shape biological diversity across generations.
 7. **Trace the flow of energy and matter through biological systems** so that they can explain how processes such as photosynthesis and cellular respiration support life.
 8. **Explain how biological systems coordinate processes to maintain function** so that they can analyze how disruptions (such as disease, toxins, or environmental stress) affect organismal health and survival.
 9. **Analyze how organisms interact with one another and with their environment** so that they can interpret population dynamics, ecological relationships, and ecosystem stability.
 10. **Evaluate how human activities influence biological systems** so that they can understand how actions such as habitat modification, resource use, and technological innovation affect ecosystems and global biological processes.
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How grading works in this course.

There are more points available than you need to earn any grade. Most categories have built-in flexibility — your lowest scores are automatically dropped so that a hard week doesn't define your semester. All three tests and the final exam are required. Everything else gives you choices about how you earn your points.



- Tests 1, 2 & 3** — 300 pts · *required*
- Final Exam** — 150 pts · *required*
- Blog Posts** — 224 pts · best 10 of 14
- Blog Comments** — 112 pts · best 10 of 14
- Learning Notes** — 240 pts · best 11 of 15
- Take-Home HW** — 100 pts · *optional*

Tests 1, 2 & 3

300 PTS AVAILABLE · ALL REQUIRED

Three exams, each worth 100 points. Taken via **Measure Learning / ProctorU** or at a certified testing center — self-scheduled within the test window. All three tests must be completed to pass the course.

Final Exam

150 PTS · REQUIRED

Comprehensive exam covering all 15 weeks of course content. Taken during finals week via Measure Learning / ProctorU or at a certified testing center.

Blog Posts

224 PTS AVAILABLE · NEED TO EARN 168 · BEST 10 OF 14 COUNT

Weekly posts responding to the prior week's content — 14 opportunities across weeks 2–15, worth 16 points each (224 points total). Your four lowest scores are automatically dropped. Posts must be in your own voice, all content must be your own creation (including images), uploaded to your blog with your declaration submitted by Sunday at 11:59 PM.

Blog Comments

112 PTS AVAILABLE · NEED TO EARN 80 · BEST 10 OF 14 COUNT

Comment on two classmates' blog posts each week following the provided instructions — 14 opportunities, worth 8 points each week (112 points total). Your four lowest scores are automatically dropped.

Learning Notes

240 PTS AVAILABLE · NEED TO EARN 176 · BEST 11 OF 15

At the end of every week, submit photos of your notes over all of that week's videos — 15 opportunities, worth 16 points each (240 points total). Use the structured template provided or your own format. Graded on completion, not on being "right" — notes must demonstrate a clear effort to correctly outline and document the learning materials thoroughly. Your four lowest weeks are automatically dropped.

Take-Home HW

100 PTS · OPTIONAL

Assignments designed to help you process the most challenging material — strongly recommended. Completing homework gives you extra points in your bank and is one of the best ways to prepare for exams. Not required, but students who skip it consistently tend to feel the difference on tests.

Grade Scale

Grades are based on total points earned out of 1,126 available. You do not need to earn all available points — the thresholds below reflect what you need.

A ≥ 900 pts

B ≥ 800 pts

C ≥ 700 pts

D ≥ 600 pts

F < 600 pts

Grades will not be bumped, altered, or otherwise changed. These are the grade cut-offs.

Canvas and Grades

These cut-offs are point totals, not percentages of the 1,126 available — there are more points available than any grade requires, on purpose. Canvas's built-in gradebook percentage struggles to reflect this correctly in a system with grade choice like this one, so use the grade calculation workbook provided in Important Links to check your standing rather than relying on the percentage Canvas shows.

* Dates and topics may be adjusted with notification on Canvas or by email.

WEEK	TOPIC	NOTES
1	Learning and The Nature of Science	
2	Biological Molecules and the Chemical Basis of Life	
3	Cells and Biological Organization	
4	Biological Membranes and Cell Signaling	
5	DNA and Genetic Variation	
6	Gene Expression	
7	Cell Division	
8	Inheritance	
9	Evolution and Natural Selection	
10	Population Genetics and Speciation	
11	Cellular Respiration	
12	Photosynthesis	
13	Biological Systems	
14	Ecosystems	
15	Human Impacts on Biological Systems	
Finals	Final Exam	ProctorU or Testing Center

Test weeks (1, 2, and 3) will be noted on Canvas when dates are confirmed. Tests are self-scheduled and do not replace weekly content.

Participation & Canvas Engagement

For success in this course you need to learn how to use Canvas. Resources to help include the [Student Canvas Videos](#) and the [Passport to Canvas](#) learning modules. You are expected to log in to Canvas on Monday morning each week.

Classroom and Online Etiquette

I am committed to creating a safe and respectful space for learning, teaching, and contributing. Instructors and students are expected to show respect and courtesy to others. All interactions should be courteous and professional regardless of platform — online or in-person.

Academic Integrity

"Being a cowboy isn't in your clothes. It's in your character."

— *From the Cowboy Code*

Participating in a behavior that violates academic integrity (unauthorized collaboration, plagiarism, multiple submissions, cheating on examinations or major assignments, fabricating information, helping another person cheat, altering or destroying the work of others, and similar behaviors) will result in a sanction. Sanctions include receiving a failing grade on an assignment, examination, or for the course — which may include an F! on your transcript.

[Academic Integrity Policy](#) — academicaffairs.okstate.edu

Learning How to Learn

We will spend time at the beginning of the course focusing on this topic. Below are a few resources:

- The [OSU LASSO Center](#) provides tutoring and support in study strategies.
- *Teach Yourself How to Learn* by Sandra Yancy McGuire (2018)
- A short video covering research-backed study strategies (<8 minutes)

Basic Needs

Any student who has difficulty affording groceries or accessing sufficient food, or who lacks a safe and stable place to live, is urged to contact the [Office of the Vice President for Student Affairs](#) for support.

Health & Wellness

College can be stressful and affect your physical and mental health. Being in good health is important for your success. Please seek help from professional resources if you feel that your physical or mental health is suffering.

- [University Health Services](#) — uhs.okstate.edu
 - [Mental Health Resources](#) — wellness.okstate.edu
 - [TimelyCare](#) — 24/7 counseling, peer support, and health coaching at no cost
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Artificial intelligence (AI) tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Copilot, etc.) may be used only as a learning aid to support your understanding of biology concepts. All homework and writing assignments must be completed independently and in your own voice.

✓ PERMITTED USES

- Explore or review general biology concepts covered in lecture, readings, or prior coursework
- Ask for alternative explanations, analogies, or summaries of topics
- Identify areas of confusion to guide further studying
- Create practice higher-order thinking test questions
- Help plan how to study or approach learning the material (not how to answer a specific question)

✗ PROHIBITED USES

- Answer, solve, or complete any homework question, in whole or in part
- Paste, upload, paraphrase, or submit any homework prompt, question, dataset, figure, or scenario into an AI tool
- Use AI to generate explanations, calculations, or written responses that directly address a homework question or writing assignment
- Use AI-generated language, reasoning, or structure as a template for your answers, even if you rewrite it

"In Your Own Voice" Requirement

All homework responses and writing assignments must be written in your own voice, reflecting your personal understanding of the material. Your voice should sound like a college freshman. You must be able to explain and defend your reasoning without reliance on external tools. Work that reflects AI-style phrasing, structure, or reasoning — rather than your own thinking — may be treated as unauthorized assistance.

AI may help you learn the material, but it may not help you produce the work.

Why This Policy Exists

Learning biology requires you to practice thinking through problems yourself. Homework and writing assignments are far less about getting the correct answer than about developing your ability to reason, explain biological processes, and apply concepts in your own words. If an AI tool does the thinking, structuring, or explaining for you, then you are not doing the learning. This policy exists to ensure that assignments support real understanding, prepare you for exams and future courses, and reflect your own developing scientific voice.

Use of AI beyond the limits described above constitutes unauthorized assistance and a violation of the academic integrity policy — including cases where AI use cannot be conclusively proven but submitted work shows strong evidence of external generation. If you are unsure whether a specific use is allowed, do not use it and ask **before** completing the assignment.

Student Accessibility Services

If you have a disability (e.g., learning disability, temporary or permanent physical condition) or even suspect you might — that requires accessibility services (e.g., extended testing time, particular testing needs) — please see [Student Accessibility Services \(accessibility.okstate.edu\)](https://accessibility.okstate.edu). They can instruct you regarding accommodations. ***It is then your responsibility to inform me of your needs***, if you so desire. Please do this as early as possible so that I can make the necessary arrangements. I am legally bound to treat such information as confidential and will be happy to work with you.

⚠ **Accessibility accommodations are NOT automatically implemented. You must speak with the instructor of each course to discuss accommodations and how they can be implemented in that specific course.**

Virtual Office Hours

Virtual office hours are held via Zoom — see Canvas for the link and schedule. You are also welcome to schedule an individual meeting. I am here to help; please do not hesitate to reach out.

The most important thing you can do: talk to me.

I can't help if I don't know you need it. Please reach out early and often — for questions about course material, personal circumstances affecting your work, or anything else. Email is always the fastest route: jodie.wiggins@okstate.edu.

Additional Resources

- **OSU LASSO Center** — tutoring and academic support: success.okstate.edu/lasso-center
- **University Health Services**: uhs.okstate.edu
- **Mental Health & Wellness**: wellness.okstate.edu
- **TimelyCare** — 24/7 free counseling: timelycare.com/okstate
- **Vice President for Student Affairs**: vpsao@okstate.edu

Please see the OSU syllabus attachment on Canvas for frequently asked questions related to courses at OSU.